CAPYBARA

Hydrochoerus hydrochaeris

PART A — WHO IS THIS ANIMAL?

WHERE DOES IT LIVE?

South America — wetlands, rivers, and flooded grasslands

IS IT SAFE OR IN DANGER?

Common in the wild

PART B — HOW THIS LIVING SYSTEM WORKS

1. WHAT CAN IT SEE, HEAR, OR FEEL?

- Its eyes are set high on its head to spot danger from above.
- It hears soft splashing sounds and barks from group members.
- Its nose picks up the scent of each animal in its group.
- It feels vibrations in the water when something moves nearby.

Observation Prompt: What do you see it paying attention to right now?

2. WHERE DOES IT LIVE — AND WHY?

- It lives near rivers, ponds, and flooded grasslands.
- Water lets it hide quickly when a predator comes close.
- It grazes on grasses that grow along the water's edge.
- Mud baths keep it cool and protect its skin from the sun.

Observation Prompt: What would happen if this habitat changed?

3. HOW DOES IT SEND MESSAGES?

- It barks sharply to warn the group of a nearby threat.
- Young ones hum and purr almost constantly to stay in contact.
- Males rub a scent gland on their snout onto plants to mark territory.
- A low whistle from a female signals that she is ready to mate.

Observation Prompt: Can you spot a behavior that might be a signal?

4. WHAT DOES IT DO WHEN SOMETHING CHANGES?

- When startled, the whole group rushes into the nearest water.
- It can hold its breath underwater for several minutes.
- After disturbance, it becomes more active at night and more cautious during the day.
- It stands still and alert before deciding whether to flee.

Observation Prompt: What happened when someone walked by?

5. HOW DOES IT LEARN?

- Young capybaras learn to graze by following adults to feeding spots.
- They stay near the group and watch adults for cues about danger.
- Babies hear alarm calls and quickly learn which sounds mean run.

Observation Prompt: Does this behavior look practiced?

6. HOW DOES IT HAVE BABIES?

- A female gives birth to two to eight young at one time.
- Babies can walk, swim, and eat grass within their first week.
- Several females in a group share nursing duties for all the young.
- Young stay close to adults for protection from eagles and caimans.

Observation Prompt: What might babies need to survive?

7. WHAT ARE ITS LIMITS?

- It must stay close to water, or it cannot escape large predators.
- High heat slows it down; it rests in water or mud during hot hours.
- Loud sudden sounds trigger the whole group to stop or scatter.
- It cannot survive long in areas where water dries up completely.

Observation Prompt: What could make this animal leave or stop moving?

8. WHAT DOES THIS TEACH US ABOUT LIFE?

- One animal watching the edge of the water protects the whole group.
- A habitat that looks safe from above may hide danger below.
- What keeps it calm — shade, water, quiet — tells you what it needs.

Final Question: Is what you see the whole story — or just part of it?

What a living thing can sense becomes its reality.
Every system lives inside its environment.